

What's up with 'verbal' morphology in BCS agent nominals?

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Introduction



https://www.masabeslin.com/assets/pdf/beslin_fdsl_nominals.pdf

Introduction

MAIN CLAIM:

‘Verbal’ morphology in Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian agentive nouns is not verbal.

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- I'll be looking at a sample of BCS agentive nominals, which contain what is traditionally analyzed as verbal morphology

- | | | | | | | |
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| (1) | a. | pozn-av-á-telj
know-AV-TH-N
'expert' | b. | prouč-av-á-telj
study-AV-TH-N
'researcher' | c. | reš-av-á-telj
solve-AV-TH-N
'solver' |
| (2) | a. | predsed-av-a-áč
chair-AV-TH-N
'chair' | b. | pred-av-a-áč
lecture-AV-TH-N
'lecturer' | c. | ugnjjet-av-a-áč
oppress-AV-TH-N
'oppressor' |
| (3) | a. | prod-av-a-ác
sell-AV-TH-N
'seller' | b. | dar-o-d-av-a-ác
gift-L-give-AV-TH-N
'giftgiver' | c. | posl-o-d-av-a-ác
job-L-give-AV-TH-N
'employer' |

- A noun like *proučavatelj* is often segmented as *pro-uč-a-va-telj* 'LP-learn-V-SI-N', because of the similar verbs *proučavati* 'be researching', *proučiti*, and *učiti*

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- A noun like *proučavatelj* is often segmented as *pro-uč-a-va-telj* 'LP-learn-V-SI-N', because of the similar verbs *proučavati* 'be researching', *proučiti*, and *učiti*
- ★ We'll see reasons to doubt that these nouns have verbal structure

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- I'll show BCS root-conditioned allomorphy and accent placement are limited to the **first spellout domain, including only one categorizing morpheme**
- ★ Then, the 'verbal' morphology in these agent nominals may not be verbal after all

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- §1 Some background on Distributed Morphology (DM), cyclic domains, the role of categorizers, and allomorphy

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- Theme vowels as morphemes that attach to (certain) roots more generally;
- 'Lexical prefixes' observed in contexts in which a deverbal analysis is dubious

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§4 Conclusions

Theoretical background & assumptions

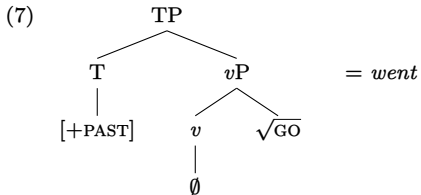
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- Words are built up syntactically out of (discrete) abstract morphemes which receive form (and meaning) at the interfaces
- Morphemes: roots and functional heads (including categorizers)
- The form (and meaning) of a morpheme may be contextually determined, (7)
- Allomorphs are in competition with each other ('Elsewhere principle')



Theoretical background & assumptions

- Transfer to the interfaces happens cyclically, at certain points of the derivation
- Categorizers (v , n , a) are the relevant cyclic heads

(8) Schematization of cyclic domains (Embick 2014):

a. Cyclic y merged in $[y [X [Y [x \sqrt{\text{ROOT}} \dots]]]]$

b. Cyclic domain centered on $x = [X [Y [x \sqrt{\text{ROOT}}]]]$ sent to interfaces

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→ Intended outcome: The root is accessible to the first cyclic head x and any intervening non-cyclic heads (X , Y) (think *go-went*)

→ $\sqrt{\text{ROOT}}$ and y cannot interact for the purposes of allomorph selection because they are in separate spell-out domains

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- The root-conditioned *n*-allomorphy in (9) compared to (10) is thought to arise due to a structural difference: root-derived versus deverbal nouns

(9) marri-**age**, grow-**th**, remov-**al**, free-**dom**, divers-**ity**, strateg-**y**, ...

(10) marry-**ing**, grow-**ing**, remov-**ing**, free-**ing**, divers-ify-**ing**, strateg-iz-**ing**, ...

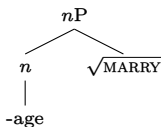
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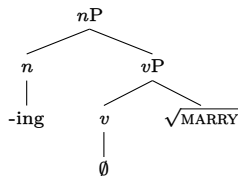
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(11) a.



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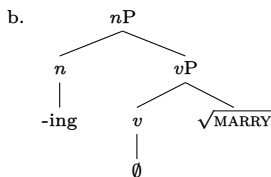
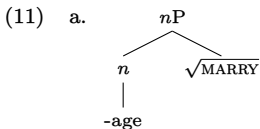


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→ Categorization has the same effect on allomorphy and accent placement in BCS

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 - Root-conditioned allomorphy
 - Accent placement
- I'll contrast the behavior of deadjectival and root-derived (agentive) nouns
- In §3, we'll see that 'deverbal' agentive nouns pattern with root-derived nouns

Root-nominals vs. deadjectival nominals: ALLOMORPHY

- Looking again at agent nominals, the broadly agentive *n*-suffixes in BCS are at least *-ar*, *-aš*, *-er*, *-(a)c*, *-ač*, *-ic(a)*, *-ik*, and *-džij(a)*
- Root-derived nouns (**ROOT-*n***) may take any of the *n*-allomorphs on offer; the choice of *n* is determined by the root ('lexically-conditioned allomorphy')

(12) a. kormil-**ar** 'helmsman'

b. batin-**aš** 'beater'

c. poz-**er** 'poser'

d. pis-**ac** 'writer'

e. voz-**ač** 'driver'

f. izdaj-**ica** 'traitor'

g. proza-**ik** 'prose writer'

h. bureg-**džija** 'börek maker'

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- NB:** I clearly do not subscribe to the view that all agentive nouns contain verbal structure, even if they seem to correspond to the external argument of a verb

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| a. | <i>prlj-av-ac</i> ‘dirty one’ | d. | <i>peg-av-ac</i> ‘freckled one’ |
| b. | <i>mrš-av-ac</i> ‘skinny one’ | e. | <i>prg-av-ac</i> ‘grumpy one’ |
| c. | <i>mut-av-ac</i> ‘mute one’ | f. | <i>hvalis-av-ac</i> ‘boastful one’ |

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- A root may determine the choice of *n* only if *n* is the first-merged categorizer
- If *a* intervenes between the root and *n* (**ROOT-*a*-*n***), the root can no longer determine the form of *n* (13)-(16)

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- (14) a. *plaš-ljiv-ac* ‘scared one’
b. *smrd-ljiv-ac* ‘stinky one’
c. *grab-ljiv-ac* ‘predatory one’

- d. *povod-ljiv-ac* ‘gullible one’
e. *var-ljiv-ac* ‘cheating one’
f. *vaš-ljiv-ac* ‘lousy one’

Root-nominals vs. deadjectival nominals: ALLOMORPHY

- (15) a. hajduk-*ov-ac* ‘H. supporter’
b. dinam-*ov-ac* ‘D. supporter’
c. isus-*ov-ac* ‘Jesuit’
d. maček-*ov-ac* ‘Maček follower’
e. nobel-*ov-ac* ‘Nobel winner’
f. oskar-*ov-ac* ‘Oscar winner’
- (16) a. smrt-*n-ik* ‘mortal one’
b. put-*n-ik* ‘traveler’
c. boles-*n-ik* ‘sick one’
d. bestid-*n-ik* ‘shameless one’
e. duž-*n-ik* ‘debtor’
f. gubit-*n-ik* ‘loser’

- Only *a* can now influence the form of *n*, which is uniform regardless of the root in question (either due to *a*-conditioned allomorphy or *elsewhere*)

Root-nominals vs. deadjectival nominals: ALLOMORPHY

- The locality effect is best observed when the same root can produce both a root-nominal and a deadjectival nominal (cf. **gubit-n-aš*, **gubit-ik*)
- Same root, same meaning, different nominalizer due to the presence of *a*

(17) a. *gubit-aš*
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 - This can be accounted for if *a* and *n* are cyclic heads
- In a **ROOT-*a*-*n*** configuration, the root is spelled out when *n* is merged, hence the root (*qua* morpheme) can no longer be identified when *n* undergoes VI

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- Bešlin (forthcoming): Pitch-prominence in BCS is realized on the **structurally highest accent-marked element in the first spellout domain**
- The nominalizer $-(\acute{a})c$ is underlyingly accent-marked, but only realizes that accent if it is in **ROOT-*n***, not in e.g., **ROOT-*a-n***

(18) a. $\text{pis} \rightarrow \text{pis-}\acute{a}c$
 $\sqrt{\text{write}}$ 'writer'

b. $\text{al}\acute{z}\acute{i}r \rightarrow \text{al}\acute{z}\acute{i}r-}\acute{a}c$
 $\sqrt{\text{algeria}}$ 'Algerian(N)'

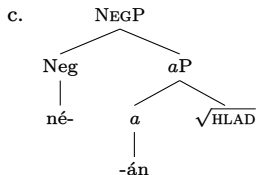
(19) a. $\text{p}\acute{f}l\text{j-}av \rightarrow \text{p}\acute{f}l\text{j-}av-}\acute{a}c$
 'dirty' 'dirty one'

b. $\text{smrd-lj}\acute{i}v \rightarrow \text{smrd-lj}\acute{i}v-}\acute{a}c$
 'stinky' 'stinky one'

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- If the extended projection of the first categorizer contains non-cyclic heads (e.g., DEG, NEG, DIM) and their exponents are accented, the accent surfaces on them

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NEG-cold-A
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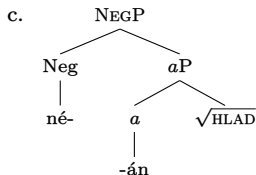


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- Accent placement is determined within the first spellout domain, as in (8)/(21)

(21) Schematization of cyclic domains (Embick 2014):

a. Cyclic y merged in [y [X [Y [x $\sqrt{\text{ROOT}}$...]]]

b. Cyclic domain centered on x = [X [Y [x $\sqrt{\text{ROOT}}$]]] sent to interfaces

Root-nominals vs. deadjectival nominals: ACCENT

- Root-root compounds behave as expected; the accent placement is still ‘frozen’ in the spellout domain of the first **categorizer**

(22) a. dub-o-rez-ác
deep-L-cut-N
‘woodcarver’

b. pad-o-bran-ác
fall-L-defend-N
‘parachuter’

c. led-o-lom-ác
ice-L-break-N
‘ice-breaker’

Root-nominals vs. deadjectival nominals

INTERIM SUMMARY I:

Root-conditioned allomorphy and accent placement in BCS are limited to the first spellout domain, including *one* categorizer

‘Deverbal’ nouns

§1 Some background on Distributed Morphology (DM), cyclic domains, the role of categorizers, and allomorphy

§2 Data from root-derived* vs. deadjectival agent nominals (Bešlin forthcoming)

- (I) **Root-conditioned allomorphy** and (II) **accent placement** determined in the first spellout domain, centered around the first-merged categorizer

→ Second-merged categorizer can’t ‘see’ the root and can’t realize its accent

→ This follows from a DM conception of cyclic domains

§3 Back to ‘deverbal’ agentive nouns...

- A general note about verbal structure in agentive nouns
- They pattern in (I) and (II) with root-derived nouns (one categorizer)
- An alternative analysis for ‘verbal’ morphemes ($\neq$ verbal extended projection)

→ The morpheme *av* as a root (also Quaglia et al. 2022);

→ Theme vowels as morphemes that attach to (certain) roots more generally;

→ ‘Lexical prefixes’ observed in contexts in which a deverbal analysis is dubious

§4 Conclusions

Agentive noun $\neq$ verbal structure

- Originally, eventive (episodic) interpretation = complement structure = verbal syntax (23a), but cf. (23b-c)

- (23) a. a frequent consumer *(of tobacco)
 b. a frequent visitor
 c. a frequent subject *(of Monet's paintings)

- Then, Alexiadou & Schäfer 2010 propose that both episodic and dispositional agent nominals have an articulated verbal structure, including *v*, Voice, and Asp
- Why no accusative case on complements or adverbial modification?
- Completely divorced from the syntax, accounting for the fact that the *-er* nominals denote the (external) argument of the corresponding verb
- But we know agent entailments $\neq$ Voice, cf. *hastily* in (24)

- (24) The rock rolled down the hill quickly/#hastily.

Agentive noun $\neq$ verbal structure

- Moreover, if *painter* needs Voice, does *thief* too?
- Event entailments also don't implicate the presence of *v*; cf. (25a)/(25b-c), (26)

- (25) a. a beautiful dancer
 b. a beautiful violinist
 c. an elegant midfielder

- (26) a. a just ruler
 b. a just king

- At the broadest level, entailments $\neq$ the presence of hidden structure

- (27) a. an illegitimate blond child

‘Deverbal’ nouns: ALLOMORPHY

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- As we saw in the beginning, there are different *n*-allomorphs in ‘deverbal’ nouns

- (28) a. pozn-av-a-**telj** b. prouč-av-a-**telj** c. reš-av-a-**telj**
 know-AV-TH-N study-AV-TH-N solve-AV-TH-N
 ‘expert’ ‘researcher’ ‘solver’
- (29) a. predsed-av-a-**ač** b. pred-av-a-**ač** c. ugnjet-av-a-**ač**
 chair-AV-TH-N lecture-AV-TH-N oppress-AV-TH-N
 ‘chair’ ‘lecturer’ ‘oppressor’
- (30) a. prod-av-a-**ac** b. dar-o-d-av-a-**ac** c. posl-o-d-av-a-**ac**
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- No syntactic difference correlates with different *ns* (e.g., argument structure)
- No semantic or phonological factors that condition the allomorphy
- ★ Allomorphy of *n* in (28)-(30) is lexically conditioned by the root

‘Deverbal’ nouns: ACCENT

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- As we also saw in the beginning, accent in our ‘deverbal’ nouns can surface on *n*-exponents that underlyingly have it (*-áč* and *-ác*):

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- Recall, accent can only surface in the first spellout domain (one categorizer)

‘Deverbal’ nouns

INTERIM SUMMARY II:

Allomorphy and accent placement patterns suggest that the *n* in BCS ‘deverbal’ agentive nouns is the first-merged categorizer.

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COROLLARY:

‘Verbal’ morphology inside these agentive nouns is not verbal.

What of the ‘verbal’ morphology, then? THE STATUS OF AV

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- The morphemes exponed by *-av* and *-iv* appear in so-called secondary imperfective verbs and signal a shift in aspect (34)-(35)

(34) a. prouč-i-ti
study-TH-INF
‘research’

b. prouč-av-a-ti
study-AV-TH-INF
‘be researching’

(35) a. zatašk-a-ti
coverup-TH-INF
‘cover up’

b. zatašk-iv-a-ti
coverup-IV-TH-INF
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- They also appear in *some* agent nominals; same meaning in (36a-b) vs. (36c-d)

(36) a. prouč-av-a-telj
study-AV-TH-N
‘researcher’

c. uruč-i-telj
serve-TH-N
‘process server’

b. zatašk-iv-a-ač
coverup-IV-TH-N
‘cover up agent’

d. istovar-a-ač
unload-TH-N
‘unloader’

What of the ‘verbal’ morphology, then? THE STATUS OF AV

- They can appear in the context of so-called verbs of creation
(cf. Kratzer 2000, Embick 2004)

(37) 3D štampač je pokvaren pa je maketa izašla
 3D printer is broken so is model came_out
 iz-u-niš-av-a-n-a / is-pre-sav-ij-a-n-a.
 SP-LP-destroy-AV-TH-PTCP-F.SG SP-LP-bend-IJ-TH-PTCP-F.SG
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- Quaglia et al. (2022): They also appear in the derivation of (seemingly) simple nouns and adjectives—they are **bound roots**

(38) a. ruk-av-∅
 arm-AV-N.M.SG.NOM
 ‘sleeve’
 b. bles-av-∅
 silly-AV-A.M.SG.NOM
 ‘silly’
 c. maz-iv-o
 daub-IV-N.NEUT.SG.NOM
 ‘grease’
 d. jez-iv-o
 shudder-IV-A.NEUT.SG.NOM
 ‘creepy’

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STATUS OF AV

I tentatively conclude with Quaglia et al. (2022) that *av* is a root.

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If all major word classes have THs, THs could then equally well be attributed to roots, as in (39) (with contextual allomorphy able to work in the familiar way)

- (39)
- ROOT-TH-*n*
 - ROOT-TH-*a*
 - ROOT-TH-*v*
 - ROOT-TH-ROOT

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- a. ROOT-TH-*n*
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 - c. ROOT-TH-*v*
 - d. ROOT-TH-ROOT

→ If this is correct, then the appearance of a TH does not necessarily indicate the presence of a verbal categorizing morpheme

What of the ‘verbal’ morphology, then? THE STATUS OF LPS

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- Is the decomposition always synchronic? Experimental work needed:

(40)	a.	d-a-ti	b.	pro -d-a-ti	c.	pro -d-a-av-ac
		give-TH-INF		LP?-give-TH-INF		LP?-give-TH-AV-N
		‘give’		‘sell’		‘seller’

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	‘give’	‘sell’	‘seller’

- LPs appear in all sorts of words for which a deverbal analysis is dubious (41)

(41)	a. na -uč-i-ti	b. na -uk-a	c. na -uk-∅
	LP?-study-TH-INF	LP?-learn-N.NOM.SG	LP?-learn-N.NOM.SG
	‘learn/teach’	‘science’	‘lesson’

→ Also *pred-stava* ‘play’, *pre-preka* ‘barrier’, *o-stava* ‘pantry’, *iz-reka* ‘proverb’, etc.

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- I showed that ‘deverbal’ agentive nouns containing morphology analyzed as verbal behave for these morphophonological processes like root-derived nouns
- No syntactic evidence for verbal structure in agentive nouns; event/agent entailments do not provide evidence either
- I argued that *av* should be analyzed as a root, and suggested that THs and LPS may not necessarily signal the presence of verbal structure either

- I'm grateful to Masha Polinsky, Dave Embick, Tanja Milićev, Norbert Hornstein, Alex Chabot, Bill Idsardi, Heather Newell, Tobias Scheer, Hannah Sande, Jim Wood, the audience at NELS 55, & the participants of Yale's Syntax Reading Group and UMD's S-lab for valuable discussion and feedback on various aspects of this work.

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Appendix A: Post-accenting elements

- There is a group of examples that form a systematic exception to the accent generalizations made here—so-called “post-accenting” elements (Halle 1997)
- Have an underlying accent, but realize it on the syllable following them
- Assuming the existence of such elements allows us to avoid having a list of pairs of suffixes that are segmentally identical and only differ in presence/absence of accent (uniform for two kinds of roots); root in (a)-(g) is post-accenting

(42)	a.	loz-á	‘grape-N.NOM.SG.F’	h.	dúnj-a	‘quince-N.NOM.SG.F’
	b.	loz-é	‘grape-N.GEN.SG.FEM’	i.	dúnj-e	‘quince-N.GEN.SG.F’
	c.	loz-í	‘grape-N.DAT.SG.F’	j.	dúnj-i	‘quince-N.DAT.SG.F’
	d.	loz-ú	‘grape-N.ACC.SG.F’	k.	dúnj-u	‘quince-N.ACC.SG.F’
	e.	loz-óm	‘grape-N.INST.SG.F’	l.	dúnj-om	‘quince-N.INST.SG.F’
	f.	loz-í.ca	‘grape-N.DIM-F’	m.	dúnj-ic-a	‘quince-N.DIM-F’
	g.	loz-óv	‘grape-A.POSS’	n.	dúnj-ev	‘quince-A.POSS’